Knowledge organiser (TRACK) — The local canvas: architectural line and form

Pathway: TRACK · Week 1 Part 2 · Big question: How can we use structural line, negative space, and surface frottage to record built architecture?

Core studio focus

Family: Studio suite

Big question: How can we use structural line, negative space, and surface frottage to record built architecture?

• Analyse how girders, arches, and trusses lock together in engineered structures.

• Use negative-space observation to draw the open shapes between structural beams accurately.

• Layer directional line weights over textured surface studies to show depth.

Essential vocabulary

• negative space: The open air gaps and shapes trapped between solid beams.

• truss: A rigid framework of steel or timber beams arranged in repeating triangles.

• line weight: Varying line thickness from light construction lines to heavy foreground edges.

• frottage: Taking a surface texture rubbing with graphite or wax over a relief surface.

• proportion: The size relationship between height, span, and beam thickness.

Three-step studio method

Step 1: Lay down a subtle texture ground: I take a light graphite rubbing from a mesh and corrugated plate across two zones of my sheet.

Step 2: Map the outer envelope and negative spaces: I sketch the overall bounding box, then draw the triangle and arch sky gaps inside.

Step 3: Build structural line weight: I press firmly with a 4B pencil and fineliner on the front girders so they step forward in space.